Tristan Morrow: Session#4

Key Outcomes

Tristan and his therapist/coach Jithendran conducted a structured hypnotherapy session focused on identifying the root cause of Tristan's persistent anxiety, social withdrawal, and feelings of inadequacy. The session revealed that Tristan's current emotional responses — particularly in group settings — are driven by unresolved childhood trauma linked to a confusing relationship with his uncle, who was both supportive and physically frightening. Inner child work was performed under hypnosis to help Tristan's adult self integrate with and heal his wounded inner child, releasing long-held defensive beliefs around abandonment, incompetence, and unworthiness. Tristan emerged from the session feeling more complete and integrated, with clear homework to reinforce the work before the next session. [1] [2]

Session Context and Presenting Issues

- **Ongoing anxiety:** Tristan reported a persistent low-level anxiety throughout his workday, present even after attempting cognitive reframing techniques from prior sessions. [3]
- **Reframing fatigue:** The positive effects of earlier reframing work (shifting from a "victim" to a "helper" narrative) lasted approximately one to one-and-a-half weeks before fading; by the current session, the reframing felt forced and numbing rather than genuine. [4] [5]
- **Social group trigger:** A specific incident in a group setting on Tuesday left Tristan feeling powerless, unworthy, and alone — the central case study for this session. [6] [7]

Root Cause Identified: Childhood Trauma Mapping

- Tristan's discomfort in group settings stems not from the people themselves but from **emotional mapping** — present-day social situations unconsciously trigger memories of his uncle. [8]
- His uncle was a contradictory figure: **supportive and admired**, yet also **physically frightening**, creating a fused emotional response of fear and admiration that now

resurfaces in any close social dynamic. [8]

- This produces an **inner conflict** between the conscious mind (which recognizes that current people are safe and different) and the subconscious mind (which insists the situation mirrors past harm). [9]
- Tristan projects **resentment** onto group members, perceiving them as more emotionally mature — specifically because they can lower their guard and accept connection, whereas he feels compelled to withdraw when others try to get close. [10] [7]
- When group members offer compliments or attempt connection, Tristan's instinct is to **pull away**, preoccupied with his own anxiety rather than receiving the interaction. [7]

Why Cognitive Reframing Alone Is Insufficient

- Beliefs formed over long periods become **neurologically cemented** — the brain's homeostasis resists change even when the change is beneficial, because familiarity (even painful familiarity) feels safe. [11]
- Suffering can feel preferable to change because the body is **habituated to the known state**; new positive states can themselves generate anxiety. [12]
- Reframing in a conscious, waking state cannot fully reach beliefs stored **somatically** — in body tissue, the nervous system, and cells — which is why thinking-based tools catch but cannot erase deep emotional patterns. [13]
- Effective reprogramming requires entering a **hypnotic/trance state**, particularly just before sleep, when the subconscious is most receptive and the body rewires itself without external disturbance. [14] [15]

Therapeutic Approach Selected: Inner Child Work

Why inner child work over other modalities:

- Tristan explicitly preferred this approach and noted that directly revisiting traumatic memories in past therapy worsened his anxiety for days afterward; he requested that memory-retrieval work be deferred until later sessions. [16]

- Jithendran confirmed this matched his planned approach — bringing the inner child into a safe imaginal space rather than re-exposing Tristan to the trauma directly. [16]

Other modalities explained for future sessions:

- **Cord cutting:** A hypnotherapy technique to sever the emotional dependency bond with a person (described as analogous to a divorce — mutual release with respect but full independence). [17]
- **Cord realignment:** Used when a relationship cannot or should not be ended; involves establishing healthy boundaries and forgiveness while maintaining the relationship. [17] [18]
- Both cord-based techniques were deferred pending evaluation of how inner child work progresses. [19]

Hypnotherapy Session: Step-by-Step Process

Induction and Deepening

- Tristan was guided to close his eyes, focus on breath, and visualize his "happy face" — his identity as a helper and protector — as an anchor image. [20] [21]
- A countdown from 5 to 0 was used, with each number deepening relaxation; followed by a staircase visualization (10 steps descending into the subconscious mind). [21] [22] [23]
- Physical relaxation was guided progressively from crown to toe, with explicit instruction to **release burdens placed on him by others** — feelings of insufficiency, incompetence, and worthlessness framed as externally imposed, not intrinsic. [24]

Releasing Stored Beliefs

- Tristan was guided to a **private screening room** where all released negative feelings took visible shape on a large screen — externalized from his body so they could be observed safely from a distance. [25] [26]
- He was instructed to **drain the color** from the screen, turning vivid emotional images into fading black-and-white photographs, then into pixelated, meaningless symbols with no power over him. [26] [27]

Somatic Identification

- Tristan was guided to recall the Tuesday group feeling and locate **where in his body** that feeling physically lives (stomach, chest, throat, shoulders, or ribs). [28]
- Jithendran explained this as **psychosomatic physiology** — the belief is stored in the body, not the mind, which is why cognitive tools cannot fully erase it. [13]
- That bodily sensation was used as a **thread/compass** to trace the feeling back to its origin point in childhood. [13] [29]

Meeting the Inner Child

- Tristan's adult self was guided through the mist of the past to encounter his **younger self** at the age when the suffering began — the subconscious was trusted to identify the correct age without conscious selection. [30] [31]
- The adult Tristan approached the child with **open arms and steady presence**, the mist parting not by force but by the adult's arrival. [31]
- The child was identified as having formed **two core false beliefs** in the absence of any adult explanation: [32]
  - *"People who should be here are not — therefore I must not be worth being here for."* (abandonment → unworthiness)
  - *"The people who are here are angry — therefore I must be causing it."* (guilt → self-blame)
- The adult Tristan was guided to **correct these beliefs directly** to the child: the events were not the child's fault; the child was pure and innocent; the guilt and shame are not his to carry. [32] [33]

Releasing the Defensive Strategy

- The child's withdrawal, distrust, and isolation were reframed not as character flaws but as a **rational survival mechanism** — a firewall and watchtower built when no other options existed. [34] [35]
- The adult acknowledged and **thanked the protective part** for keeping the child alive, then communicated that the strategy is no longer needed and is now actively harmful to adult functioning. [35] [36]

- Tristan's subconscious was asked to signal readiness for the adult to take over the protective role — indicated by the **right index finger floating up** involuntarily. [36] [37]

Integration

- Child and adult were brought into a **safe room built by Tristan's imagination** — walls, light, floor, temperature, and sounds all constructed by him, with nothing entering without his permission. [38] [39]
- Both versions were guided to **embrace, hold hands, and fully integrate** into one; Tristan nodded to signal the integration felt complete. [39] [37]
- A deep breath was used to carry the integrated state **into every cell** of the body. [37] [40]
- Tristan was counted back up the staircase and returned to full waking awareness, with the subconscious door closed to prevent re-entry of old doubts. [40] [1]

Post-Session State and Observations

- Tristan reported feeling **"more complete"** immediately after emerging from the session. [1]
- Jithendran instructed him not to dilute the feeling with further conversation — to let it settle. [1] [2]

Reinforcement Homework (Before Next Session)

- **Before sleep each night:** Enter a relaxed, trance-like state and repeat the core messages from the session — the child's defensive mechanisms served their purpose but are no longer needed; the adult is now in charge of protection. [2]
- **During the day:** Continue attempting conscious reframing when triggered, with the understanding that daytime reframing is supplementary; the deeper reprogramming happens during the pre-sleep state. [14] [15]
- **Replay the session content:** Jithendran noted the session is recorded and will be shared so Tristan can repeat key affirmations himself. [41]

- **Consistency and repetition** are the primary drivers of lasting change — the goal is not a single breakthrough but progressive unwinding of accumulated patterns. [41] [42]

Next Steps

- **Tristan:** Practice nightly pre-sleep self-hypnosis reinforcement using today's session content until the next meeting. [2]
- **Next session (Tuesday):** Tristan provides feedback on how the integration feels in real-life social situations; Jithendran will refine the next session based on that experience. [2]
- **Future sessions (sequenced):** Cord cutting or cord realignment with the uncle figure to be considered once inner child work has stabilized; self-hypnosis technique to be formally taught in a later session. [14] [43] [44]